



Getting closer

When the winning male finds a female who's interested, he gently nudges her and moves over her. She spreads her hood in response, and they mate.

Making a nest

Looping her body, the female drags fallen leaves into a pile. She lays 20–50 eggs in the middle of the pile, then covers them with more leaves to keep them warm.

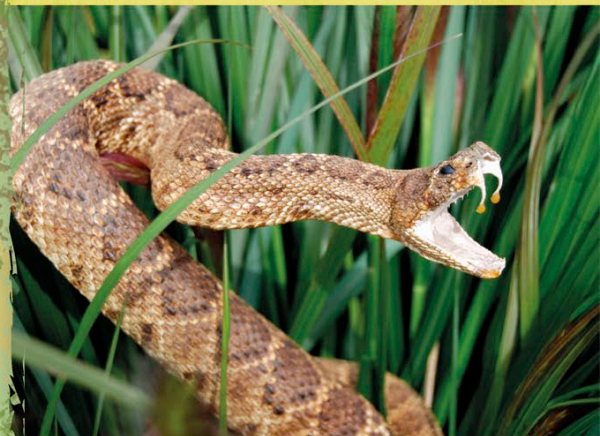
See also

Read how the female sea turtle (102–103) buries her eggs too—but doesn't stay to guard them.

Python shivers Most python mothers coil tightly around their eggs to protect them. Pythons living in cooler habitats also “shiver” their muscles to produce heat and keep the eggs warm.



Mom's fierce fangs A female rattlesnake gives birth to live young and stays with her babies for about a week or so. Any predator that comes too close risks a deadly bite from her venomous fangs.



Crocodile carrier Female Nile crocodiles help their eggs hatch by gently cracking them between their teeth. To keep the newborn crocs safe, they carry the babies to the water in their mouths.

